

SINGLE MOM SURVIVAL GUIDE

Budget, Time Management, Self-Care & Support Network

By Daniel Tesfamariam

YOU ARE DOING AN INCREDIBLE JOB

Being a single mom means doing the work of two people. You're not failing. You don't need to be perfect. You need to be consistent, present, and kind to yourself. This guide is your permission to ask for help and say no.

SINGLE MOM BUDGET WORKSHEET

MONTHLY INCOME:

Job/salary: \$ _____
Child support: \$ _____
Government assistance: \$ _____
Side income: \$ _____
Other: \$ _____
TOTAL INCOME: \$ _____

FIXED EXPENSES:

Rent/mortgage: \$ _____
Utilities: \$ _____
Phone/internet: \$ _____
Car payment: \$ _____
Insurance (health/car/life): \$ _____
Childcare/daycare: \$ _____
Debt payments: \$ _____
TOTAL FIXED: \$ _____

VARIABLE EXPENSES:

Groceries: \$ _____
Gas/transport: \$ _____
Kids activities: \$ _____
Household items: \$ _____
Clothing: \$ _____
Entertainment: \$ _____
TOTAL VARIABLE: \$ _____

REMAINING (Income - Fixed - Variable): \$ _____

TIME MANAGEMENT: WEEKLY PLANNER

You cannot do everything. Prioritize ruthlessly.

THE 3 DAILY NON-NEGOTIABLES:

1. Kids are fed, safe, and loved
2. One thing that moves life forward (bills, laundry, etc)
3. 15 minutes of self-care (non-negotiable!)

WEEKLY TIME BLOCKS:

MON: Morning: _____ After work: _____ Evening: _____

TUE: Morning: _____ After work: _____ Evening: _____

WED: Morning: _____ After work: _____ Evening: _____

THU: Morning: _____ After work: _____ Evening: _____

FRI: Morning: _____ After work: _____ Evening: _____

SAT: Morning: _____ After work: _____ Evening: _____

SUN: Morning: _____ After work: _____ Evening: _____

MEAL PREP FOR BUSY SINGLE MOMS

SUNDAY PREP (2 hours saves 5+ hours during the week):

- Cook 2 proteins (chicken + ground beef or beans)
- Prep 2-3 vegetables (chop, roast, or steam)
- Cook 2 grains (rice + pasta or quinoa)
- Prep 5 snack packs (for kids' lunches)
- Hard boil eggs (quick protein all week)

5 QUICK DINNERS (Under 20 min):

1. Tacos (precooked meat + toppings)
2. Pasta + jar sauce + pre-chopped veggies
3. Rice bowls (pre-cooked rice + protein + sauce)
4. Quesadillas + fruit
5. Breakfast for dinner (eggs, toast, fruit)

SELF-CARE (NOT OPTIONAL)

You cannot pour from an empty cup. Schedule these like appointments:

DAILY (15 min - pick one):

- Hot coffee/tea in silence before kids wake
- 5-minute journaling
- Walk around the block
- Stretching or yoga video
- Call a friend

WEEKLY (1-2 hours):

- Exercise class or home workout
- Hobby time (reading, crafting, cooking)
- Friend date (in person or phone)
- Bath/skincare/pampering

MONTHLY (half or full day):

- Solo outing (movie, shopping, nature)
- Appointment for yourself (doctor, hair, therapy)

My self-care non-negotiable: _____

Person who can watch kids for my self-care: _____

SUPPORT NETWORK MAP

You need a TEAM. Fill in your people:

Emergency childcare (drop everything): _____

Regular childcare backup: _____

Emotional support (can call crying at 2am): _____

Practical help (rides, errands, repairs): _____

Co-parent/ex (if applicable): _____

Financial advice/help: _____

Mom friend who 'gets it': _____

Professional support (therapist/counselor): _____

Pediatrician: _____

School contact: _____

RESOURCES:

- 211.org - local assistance programs
- Local food banks and clothing closets
- Single mom support groups (online and local)
- SNAP, WIC, Medicaid (if eligible)

By Daniel Tesfamariam | Asking for help is strength, not weakness.